



CARL SULLENBERGER / CHRONICLE

Upper Sandusky's Jon Diebler, the Ohio State recruit and all-time leading scorer in Ohio history, shows Olmsted Falls' Alex Sedlay that he can play defense too. Diebler scored 32 Saturday, 10 below his average, but also suffered a broken nose.

FALLS

From B1

The slowest period of the game was a 20-minute delay when Jon Diebler, Upper Sandusky's 6-foot-7 senior headed for Ohio State next season, suffered a broken nose when he collided with the Bulldogs' Tim Mansell with 3:46 to play.

In Diebler's absence, Sparks scored seven of his 17 points and brought Falls back from 79-72 behind to 81-79. Diebler, sporting a plastic faceguard, returned to the game with 2:28 to go.

Diebler, Ohio high school basketball's career scoring leader, finished with 32 points. He was just 8-for-21 from the field (2-for-9 on 3-point tries), but hit 14-of-20 at the foul line. Diebler was 9-of-12 at the line in the fourth.

Falk added 24 points for the Rams, including 14-of-16 at the foul line. Falk was 6-of-8 free throw shooting in the final period.

Dave Pellerite led Olmsted Falls with 23 points, 19 in the first half, before fouling out with 4:55 to play. He was the first Falls player

to go. Pat Pellerite, his younger brother, was next at 3:25 remaining. Bungard left at 2:48 and Sedlay fouled out with 44 seconds left.

"I've been doing this 18 years and this is the most proud I've been of any team I've coached," Donahue said. "The kids off the bench played as hard as they could. They did a good job."

The loss denied Donahue a first trip to the state Final Four. Olmsted Falls has won nine district titles under Donahue.

Turnovers were also a problem for the Bulldogs. They had 33 to 22 for Upper Sandusky. One area where Falls was superior was rebounding, outdueling the Rams on the boards 49-30.

"They do a lot of what we do," Upper Sandusky coach Keith Diebler said. "It was a question of who would do it better. We feel lucky."

Olmsted Falls never led by more than two points. The Bulldogs' last lead was 54-53 with 2:46 to go in the third quarter.

Upper Sandusky was ahead 74-61 after a 12-2 run in the fourth quarter before Falls

trimmed the margin to two.

"They did a real good job of getting out of our game," Donahue said. "We got back in it because we started playing our game. It just wasn't enough."

Falls was down 84-81 and in possession of the ball with 1:42 to play. A turnover and two free throws by Falk at 1:30 and a layup by Travis Bachtell put the Rams ahead 88-81 with 55 seconds to go.

The Bulldogs were 33-of-72 field goal shooting and 9-of-13 at the foul line.

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Upper Sandusky 91, Olmsted Falls 81

OLMSTED FALLS (81): Mike Stallard 3-1-7, Dave Pellerite 10-0-23, Tyler Sparks 7-2-17, Alex Sedlay 5-2-12, Pat Pellerite 3-2-10, Kyle Bungard 3-1-7, Brandon Welber 0-0-0, Mark Hurrell 0-0-0, Kevin Moenrich 0-0-0, Jim Brabene 1-0-2, Scott Kimmey 0-1-1, Tim mMansell 1-0-2. Totals 33-9-81.

UPPER SANDUSKY (91): Travis Bachtell 6-1-15, Jarrod Nelson 3-3-11, Drew McClellan 0-0-0, Alex Falk 5-14-24, Jon Diebler 8-14-32, Jason Baidelschies 0-0-0, Kevin Brodman 3-0-7, Cody Ollam 0-0-0, Joe Sebenier 0-1-1. Totals 25-33-81.

Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls 6 (D. Pellerite 3, P. Pellerite 2, Sparks); Upper Sandusky 8 (Bachtell 3, Diebler 2, Nelson 2, Brodman). Rebounds: Olmsted Falls 49 (Sparks 14), Upper Sandusky 36 (Diebler 11). Turnovers: Olmsted Falls 33, Upper Sandusky 22. Total fouls: Olmsted Falls 34, Upper Sandusky 15. Fouled out: D. Pellerite, P. Pellerite, Bungard, Sparks, Sedlay.

Did long delay cost Bulldogs?

Who 'nose' but it didn't help efforts

Bob Daniels
The Chronicle-Telegram

TOLEDO — Who was that masked man?

The name is Jon Diebler, he plays for Upper Sandusky and he was wearing a mask at the end of the Rams' St. Patrick's Day win over Olmsted Falls on Saturday.

It was a rough-and-tumble game that earned the Rams their second regional championship in three years and sends them into the Division II Final Four in Columbus next week.

But it cost Diebler a broken nose that delayed the game for 20 minutes while a cadre of trainers worked on him and the Bulldogs cooled their heels on the court. But that's another part of the story.

Most likely Diebler won't be wearing a mask when he reports for practice at Ohio State next fall. By then the nose will have healed.

And long before that, Diebler and his Rams will have competed in the Division II Final Four in Columbus next week seeking to take home a championship trophy to go with the one they claimed in 2005.

The 6-foot-7 Diebler, who's averaging nearly 42 points a game, scored 32 in a 91-81 victory over Olmsted Falls. The Bulldogs were shooting for their first regional crown in nine appearances.

Now, about the delay. Was it necessary to delay the game for nearly 20 minutes while Diebler was tended to, seated outside the end line with his feet on the court?

If it was necessary, then Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue has no problem with the delay — even if it interrupted a 6-2 Bulldogs run at the time.

If it wasn't necessary, then Donahue has another thought on the subject.

"Obviously you have to worry about the safety of the kids, that's first and foremost,"

he said. "I will also say it is the longest delay I have ever seen in 25 years of coaching any sport, especially for bleeding."

"I know you're worried about a head injury and I agree with that," Donahue added. "But I find it very funny that he walks off the floor, changes jerseys and comes right back to the scoring table. If it's the kid's safety, fine. If it's a tactic Upper Sandusky did, then I have a problem with that."

The other side of the coin is, was Diebler fouled on his drive to the basket with 3:46 left in the game? No foul was called. Someone asked Keith Diebler, the Rams' coach and Diebler's dad, what happened on the play.

"What did you see?" asked the coach.

"It looked to me like he was hit in the face with the ball," was the reply.

"OK," said Diebler. "OK."

Then Diebler said he thought a foul should have been called on the play.

Whatever should or should not have happened, the Rams led 79-72 at the time. By the time Diebler returned at 2:28, the Bulldogs had closed the gap to 81-76, and five seconds later Falls' Tyler Sparks drilled a 3-pointer to make it an 81-79 game with 2:23 to go.

Then Bulldogs started fouling out — five in all — and their hopes for that first trip to the Final Four began slowly to erode.

"I've never had more than one guy foul out (in a game) in 18 years of (head) coaching," said Donahue. "To have five foul out in the same game, I guess we're just the worst defensive team, we're slow on our feet and we can't do anything. We haven't had more than one kid foul out all year."

A point of interest was when Diebler scored his first basket in the first quarter, he became the first Ohio player in 51 years to surpass 1,000 points in a season.

"They're a great team and they deserved to win the way they played," Donahue said of Upper Sandusky.

Then he added: "But I'd like to play it again."

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STATE PAIRINGS, RESULTS

Pairings for the 2007 boys Ohio High School Athletic Association basketball tournament. All state tournament games at Value City Arena, Columbus	Saturday, 2 p.m. DIVISION III STATE SEMIFINALS Findlay Liberty-Benton (25-0) vs. Cie. VASJ (18-7), Thursday, 10:45 a.m.; Wheelersburg (23-2) vs. Cin. N. College Hill (18-7), Thursday, 2 p.m. CHAMPIONSHIP Saturday, 10:45 a.m. DIVISION IV STATE SEMIFINALS Holgate (17-8) vs. Canal Winchester World Harvest Prep (22-0), Friday, 10:45 a.m.; Georgetown (26-0) vs. Berlin Hiland (22-4), Friday, 2 p.m. CHAMPIONSHIP March 24, 5:15 p.m. SATURDAY'S RESULTS REGIONAL FINALS DIVISION I Can. GlenOak 83, Akir. Firestone 50	Cin. Moeller 55, Newark 44 Cin. St. Xavier 49, Cin. Withrow 46 Lakewood St. Edward 66, Findlay 50 DIVISION II Cots. DeSales 76, Chillicothe 70 Day, Dunbar 73, Kettering Alter 49 Poland Seminary 69, Cie. Benedictine 58 Upper Sandusky 91, Olmsted Falls 81 DIVISION III Cin. N. College Hill 79, Cin. Purcell Marian 68 Cie. VASJ 55, Rocky River Lutheran W. 52 Findlay Liberty-Benton 59, St. Henry 45 Wheelersburg 76, Zoarville Tuscarawas Valley 44 — The Associated Press
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'HORNS

From B1

thought they had a shot at us this year. As the team started to believe in what they were doing and gaining their own identity, they found out who they were and became very hard to beat."

When Dave Mancini hit two baskets in succession as the clock ran down under two minutes, it appeared Lutheran West might just advance to next week's games in Columbus.

Mancini, who hadn't even taken a shot to that point, hit a huge basket from just inside the 3-point arc to bring the Longhorns within 51-49 with 2:20 to play. He then picked Nate Barnes' pocket to set up a 3-point bomb that put Lutheran West in front 52-51 with 1:55 left.

But Ben Shoaff hit the front end of a one-and-one to tie the game and, following a Longhorn missed free throw, Ashen Ward pulled up for a 12-footer from just inside the free throw line to put Villa Angela-St. Joseph in front, 54-52, with 11.5 seconds remaining.

"Both teams played pretty hard," Argento said. "(Ward) hit a big shot but we got what we wanted when we came back down. That's the way the game goes. It just didn't fall."

O'Hara missed a shot from the far right baseline and Maurice Haynes grabbed the rebound and was fouled. He made the first one for the final score.

Lutheran West opened the game with a flurry, scoring 10 unanswered points after relinquishing an opening basket. The Longhorns pushed the ball and did a great job breaking VASJ's full-court pressure. Jacob O'Hara tossed in a pair of 3-pointers to give the Longhorns a 10-2 lead three minutes in. Scott Voiers drilled a three late in the quarter to give the Lutherans an 18-10 lead at the first break.

"We've been running the same press-breaker since Coach Argento's been here," said 6-foot-5 senior post Mike Telzrow. "That tears every team apart. We practice every day. We know our spots. One, two passes, no dribbles, just get a layup. We practiced it. We were ready for it."

A technical foul spurred the Long-

horns to five more points to open the second quarter, giving it a 23-10 lead following a rebound basket by Telzrow off the possession following the technical called on the Viking bench.

"(VASJ) changed up the press the second half," Argento said. "They came at it a little different. We didn't attack it as much but that's OK. You don't have to score just because they're pressing. What you don't want to do is get in a hurry and then make decisions — overpenetrating and hurrying shots. You still want to stay within your team philosophy."

The Longhorns handled the press pretty well, turning the ball over just three times the first half. After intermission, Lutheran West was guilty of nine turnovers.

St. Joe's inside presence was felt all night. The Vikings had the luxury of getting the second and third attempts at the bucket or eventually getting to the foul line.

Telzrow had the game of his life in battling VASJ's giants inside. Telzrow finished with 21 points and 14 rebounds to lead both categories. His two side-kicks — 6-6 Andrew Hofener and 6-4 Jake Sermak — combined for six points and seven rebounds.

Klein Harper (6-7) and Haynes (6-4) combined for 27 points and 20 rebounds for the Vikings. Barnes finished with 11 points and 10 boards. VASJ had the advantage off the glass, 42-32.

"We just couldn't finish the game off," Telzrow said. "All credit to St. Joe's for winning this game in the clutch. I wish them the best at state."

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VASJ 55, Lutheran West 52

LUTHERAN WEST (52): Scott Voiers 3-2-9, Jake O'Hara 3-0-8, Dave Mancini 2-3-8, Mike Telzrow 9-3-21, Andrew Hofener 0-0-0, Andrew Thomas 0-0-0, Jake Sermak 2-2-6. Totals 19-10-52.

VILLA ANGELA-ST. JOSEPH (55): Nate Barnes 3-3-11, Ashen Ward 3-1-8, Ben Shoaff 2-3-7, Klein Harper 4-3-11, Maurice Haynes 7-2-16, Scott Szczepinski 0-0-0, Brian Jenkins 0-0-0, Dominick Haynes 0-0-0, Rob Muddox 1-0-2. Totals 20-12-55.

Three-point goals: Lutheran West 4 (O'Hara 2, Voiers, Mancini); Villa Angela-St. Joseph 3 (Barnes 2, Ward). Rebounds: Lutheran West 32 (Telzrow 14), Villa Angela-St. Joseph 42 (Harper 12). Field Goals: Lutheran West 19-53 (36 percent), Villa Angela-St. Joseph 20-54 (37 percent). Free Throws: Lutheran West 10-15 (66 percent), Villa Angela-St. Joseph 12-23 (52 percent). Turnovers: Lutheran West 12, Villa Angela-St. Joseph 13. Fouls: Lutheran West 18, Villa Angela-St. Joseph 15. Fouled Out: Hofener, Harper. Technical Foul: VASJ Bench.

VASJ had its hands full before finally winning

Paul Heyse
The Chronicle-Telegram

CANTON — The mold cast by this year's Lutheran West team was a difficult one for Villa Angela-St. Joseph to peg. For 9:26, the Longhorns gave the tradition-rich Vikings fits.

But it was just a matter of time before VASJ got its inside game revved up. The Longhorns gamely weathered the Vikings' fierce comeback before falling in the end. Senior point guard Dave Mancini kept Lutheran West's hopes alive to the very end, when the 'Horns' comeback chances began caving in.

He converted the only two shots he attempted on the night. Mancini first hit a field goal with 2:24 left to bring Lutheran West within two, 51-49.

"I was just waiting for an open shot," said Mancini. "I thought I would go to the hole with it, but they didn't come out."

Mancini then cleanly picked the ball from VASJ junior guard Nate Barnes with 1:58 left, then scored a 3-point basket off the conversion 17 seconds later. Unfortunately, it was the last points West scored for the night.

"They were just playing back, trying to kill the clock, so I came up on him," Mancini said. "I knew he was going to beat me to the basket, so I just pulled it out."

The momentum swing was huge, but it wasn't enough to save Lutheran West.

"Things went great for us in the beginning," said Mancini. "We played great defense on their big guys. Our shots were falling. We could get into the post. The second half, we couldn't get into the post that much."

Despite their struggles in the second half, Lutheran West fought tooth and nail until the end.

"We knew what we needed to do (after halftime)," Mancini said. "We knew we had to go inside first, then if that didn't work, throw it back out and shoot from the perimeter. Mike Telzrow had a great game. But with Andy Hofener in foul trouble, we weren't able to get many rebounds."

Mancini refused to cast blame and throw out any second doubts about the Longhorns' great season. "Nobody thought we'd get anywhere this season. They thought we were a bunch of nobodies," said Mancini.

Shouldering the load

VASJ didn't see a Richard Semrau-type player on its radar screen. But the Vikings knew enough about junior guard Scott Voiers to give him respect.

VASJ limited Voiers to 3 of 9 from the field and nine points — eight points off his 17.8 average.

"I thought we played a good game until the last couple of minutes. We made a couple bad decisions," said Voiers. "A couple things didn't go our way. If (Ashen) Ward misses that shot or Jake (O'Hara) hits that shot from the corner, the whole game is different. It was little things like that that hurt us. It really could have gone either way."

Voiers is the grandson of former longtime Bay coach Rich Voiers, who coached the Rockets through the late 1980s. "Grandpa" Voiers lives in Florida for half the year but planned to commute back to Ohio had the Longhorns advanced to the Final Four.

"The first half we were able to pressure their guards at the top a lot. We were able to clog Ward in the post," said Voiers. "The second half, they started penetrating a little more and got some good looks at the post inside. Offensive rebounds hurt us. Rebounds off missed shots or off airballs, that's what really did it to us."

Voiers suffered a deep thigh bruise in the regular-season finale against Lutheran East. It slowed him during the first part of the postseason tournament. The bruise finally healed up, and Voiers responded with 30 points in the 'Horns regional semifinal win against Campbell Memorial earlier in the week.

"It's felt 100 percent the last couple of games. It hasn't bothered me at all," said Voiers.

It was no surprise to Voiers that Lutheran West could match paces to VASJ.

"We played a lot of Division I schools in our summer league," Voiers said. "That's what prepared us the most. We played against teams like Glenville and Shaker Heights. We try to play the best competition we can to be ready for teams like we faced tonight. We know in the regular season, we won't face this type of competition."

"The only way to get ready is to do something in the offseason."